



Emergic is meant for low-cost "thin client" desktop PCs

when ISPs in India will understand that expanding broadband here in India is more profitable than providing connection to foreign agencies. There, they need to pay for connectivity."

Built upon an open-source software base to provide a low-cost, high-performance, application-rich, Windows and MS Office-compatible desktop software suite, Emergic Freedom is an affordable solution for

small businesses at Rs 3,500 per user licence.

Shakti Office, developed by CK Technologies, Chennai is an affordable, multilingual alternative to MS office. It comes in two languages: English and Hindi. In Hindi mode, it shows menus and options in Hindi. It may not be as powerful, but treads the same line of work as MS Office and offers good functionality across all its seven components- Access, Calc, Draw, Mail, Net, Show and Write and an excellent Hindi text spell check option (See "Face Off" on page 170). Compatibility issues with PowerPoint, though is a problem. Translation and transliteration from English to supported Indian languages work fine and error-free. It has good support for Hindi typing and offers ease of use, for long a concern with affordable Indian office solution.

Ankur Office, 'a complete multilingual office suite' developed by Modular InfoTech of Pune is another possible solution for the poor man's paperless office. Available in Assamese, Bengali, Gujrati, Hindi, Kannada, Konkani, Malayalam, Marathi, Oriya, Punjabi, Tamil, Telugu and English, this package is as close as it can be to the true multilingual office software solution.

Apart from features such as spell-check for all eight languages, Ankur Office also provides functionalities such as native keyboard support and localization: Help, Manual, Screens, Menu, Hints and alert messages are available in Indian languages as well.

Portability Blues: Downside Or Upside?

Compatibility issues plague indigenously developed software by the dozen. It is not just enough for an establishment to deploy a regional language software or e-mail client. It needs to ensure that e-mails written in these regional languages or typed in bilingual formats are readable in other software.



Highlights Of An Office Alternative

Ankur Office:

- ☑ Support for all major Indian languages
- ☑ Aesthetic fonts
- ☑ Fully localised
- ☑ Spellcheckers for eight Indian languages
- ☑ Supports a variety of keyboard layouts for ease of typing
- ☑ Numerous file formats supported
- ☑ Data exchange facility for other vendor font formats
- ☑ Mail Merge in the word processor
- ☑ E-mail sent from the package can be viewed by the receiver even if he or she does not have the font

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